Class 6 Social Science – Chapter 7: India's Cultural Roots

Complete textbook answers and important questions in Simple English

This chapter explains how the Vedas, Upanishads, Buddhism, Jainism, and folk and tribal traditions have shaped Indian culture. The answers below are written in easy English for Class 6 students.

Part 1: Answers to the Big Questions

Q1. What are the Vedas? What is their message?

Answer: The Vedas are among the oldest texts of India and the world. The word Veda comes from the Sanskrit word vid, which means "knowledge".

There are four Vedas:

1. Rig Veda – contains hymns and prayers.
2. Yajur Veda – contains verses and instructions connected with rituals.
3. Sama Veda – contains verses arranged for singing.
4. Atharva Veda – contains prayers, hymns and other kinds of knowledge.

The Vedic hymns were first passed from one generation to another through oral recitation. They were not originally written on palm-leaf manuscripts.

The Vedas contain prayers to different deities and ideas about nature, life and the universe. One important Vedic statement is Ekam sat, viprā bahudhā vadanti, which means "Truth is one; the wise call it by many names." It expresses the idea that different deities may represent different forms of one underlying reality.

Q2. What new schools of thought emerged in India in the first millennium BCE? What were their core principles?

Answer: Several important schools of thought developed in India during the first millennium BCE. These included Vedanta, Yoga, Buddhism and Jainism.

- Vedanta: It teaches that all existence is connected with one ultimate reality called Brahman.
- Yoga: It teaches self-discipline and practices that help control the mind and body.
- Buddhism: It teaches that suffering is connected with ignorance and attachment. It encourages wisdom, ethical conduct and mental discipline.

- Jainism: It gives great importance to non-violence, self-control and freedom from attachment.

These schools had different teachings, but many shared ideas such as karma, rebirth, self-discipline and the search for freedom from suffering and ignorance.

Q3. What is the contribution of folk and tribal traditions to Indian culture?

Answer: Folk and tribal traditions have made a rich contribution to Indian culture. They have preserved local stories, songs, dances, art, festivals, customs and belief systems.

Many tribal communities consider mountains, rivers, trees, plants and animals sacred. Their traditions have interacted with other Indian traditions over many centuries. Ideas, deities, stories and rituals have been shared in both directions.

For example, the textbook discusses the tradition that Jagannath, worshipped at Puri in Odisha, was originally a tribal deity. Some tribal communities have also adopted Hindu deities and developed their own versions of the Mahabharata and the Ramayana.

These interactions have enriched Indian culture and helped create its great diversity.

Part 2: Answers to the textbook questions and activities

Q1. If you were Nachiketa, what questions would you like to ask Yama? Write in 100–150 words.

Answer:

If I were Nachiketa, I would ask Yama, the god of death, some important questions about life and death. First, I would ask, “What happens to a person after death?” I would also ask, “Does the soul continue to exist after the body dies?” I would like to know why people experience happiness and sorrow. I would ask how a person can live a good and meaningful life. I would also ask whether our actions affect our future. Finally, I would ask how we can overcome fear, ignorance and attachment. I would listen carefully to Yama’s answers because I would want to understand the truth about life. I believe that asking thoughtful questions helps us gain knowledge and wisdom.

Q2. Explain a few central ideas of Buddhism. Briefly comment upon them.

Answer: The main ideas of Buddhism are:

1. Suffering: Human life includes suffering and dissatisfaction.
2. Cause of suffering: Ignorance and attachment are important causes of suffering.
3. End of suffering: Suffering can end when ignorance and attachment are overcome.
4. Right conduct: People should act honestly, kindly and responsibly.

5. Ahimsa: People should avoid hurting living beings.
6. Self-discipline: Meditation and control of the mind help a person develop wisdom.

These ideas encourage people to live peacefully, understand their desires and treat others with kindness.

Q3. Explain the Buddha's quotation: "Not by water is one made pure, though many people may bathe here in sacred rivers."

Answer: The Buddha's message is that simply bathing in a sacred river does not make a person truly pure. True purity comes from good thoughts, good actions, honesty and kindness. A person should avoid hatred, dishonesty and harmful behaviour. The quotation teaches us that inner goodness is more important than outward rituals alone.

Q4. Explain a few central ideas of Jainism. Briefly comment upon them.

Answer: The main ideas of Jainism include:

1. Ahimsa: Do not harm living beings through actions, words or thoughts.
2. Anekāntavāda: Reality has many aspects, so we should not assume that our own view is the only possible one.
3. Aparigraha: Avoid excessive possessions and attachment to material things.
4. Self-discipline: Control desires and actions.
5. Karma and liberation: Our actions have consequences. By overcoming harmful actions and attachments, a person can move towards liberation.

These ideas teach non-violence, respect for different viewpoints, simplicity and self-control.

Q5. Explain André Béteille's thought about tribal traditions and Hinduism.

Answer: André Béteille explained that tribal traditions and Hindu traditions have influenced each other for a very long time. Tribal communities have adopted some ideas and practices from Hindu traditions. At the same time, Hindu traditions have also been influenced by tribal beliefs, deities, stories and rituals.

This interaction has enriched both. It shows that Indian culture has developed through exchange and cooperation among different communities.

Q6. Make a list of popular gods and goddesses in your region and the festivals associated with them.

Sample answer: Students may adapt this list to their own region.

God or goddess	Festival or occasion
Lord Rama	Ram Navami, Dussehra

Lord Krishna	Janmashtami
Goddess Durga	Durga Puja, Navratri
Lord Shiva	Maha Shivaratri
Lord Ganesha	Ganesh Chaturthi
Goddess Saraswati	Vasant Panchami
Chhathi Maiya	Chhath Puja

Q7. List two or three tribal groups from your region or state. Describe some of their art and belief systems.

Sample answer for Bihar and neighbouring regions: Please check the groups most relevant to your local area with your teacher.

Tribal group	Examples of cultural traditions
Santhal	Traditional songs, dances, musical instruments and festivals connected with community life and nature
Munda	Community dances, oral traditions and beliefs connected with nature and a supreme deity
Oraon	Traditional songs, dances, festivals and community customs

Tribal communities are diverse. Their beliefs and customs should not be treated as identical; each community has its own history and traditions.

Q8. True or False

No.	Statement	Answer	Explanation
1	The Vedic hymns were written on palm-leaf manuscripts.	False	They were first passed on orally.
2	The Vedas are India’s oldest texts.	True	They are among the oldest texts of India.
3	Ekam sat, viprā bahudhā vadanti reflects a belief in the unity of cosmic powers.	True	It means truth is one, though the wise describe it in different ways.
4	Buddhism is older than the Vedas.	False	The Vedas are older than Buddhism.
5	Jainism emerged as a branch of Buddhism.	False	Jainism is an independent school of thought with its own tradition.
6	Buddhism and Jainism advocated peaceful coexistence and avoiding harm to living beings.	True	Both place great importance on non-violence.
7	Tribal belief systems are limited to spirits and minor deities.	False	Many tribal communities also have beliefs in a higher or supreme divinity.

Part 3: Important questions and answers from every topic

Topic 1: India's Cultural Roots

Q1. What do we mean by cultural roots?

Answer: Cultural roots are the old ideas, beliefs, practices, stories and traditions from which a culture has developed.

Q2. Why is Indian culture compared to a tree?

Answer: Indian culture is compared to a tree because it has many roots and branches. Different traditions are like branches, while their shared ideas and long history form a common trunk.

Q3. What are schools of thought?

Answer: Schools of thought are groups of thinkers who share similar ideas about life, the world and the nature of reality.

Q4. Name some important roots of Indian culture mentioned in this chapter.

Answer: The important roots include the Vedic tradition, Vedanta, Yoga, Buddhism, Jainism, and folk and tribal traditions.

Q5. Why is Indian culture diverse?

Answer: Indian culture is diverse because many communities have developed different languages, beliefs, art forms, customs and festivals. These communities have also exchanged ideas over many centuries.

Q6. What does the chapter mean by "mutual enrichment"?

Answer: Mutual enrichment means that different traditions learn from and influence one another, making each richer.

Topic 2: The Vedas and Vedic Culture

Q1. What does the word "Veda" mean?

Answer: The word "Veda" comes from the Sanskrit word vid, which means "to know" or "knowledge".

Q2. Name the four Vedas.

Answer: The four Vedas are the Rig Veda, Yajur Veda, Sama Veda and Atharva Veda.

Q3. How were the Vedic hymns preserved?

Answer: They were preserved through careful oral recitation. Teachers passed them on to students from generation to generation.

Q4. What is a hymn?

Answer: A hymn is a song or poem of praise or prayer, often addressed to a deity.

Q5. What is the Rig Veda?

Answer: The Rig Veda is the oldest of the four Vedas. It contains many hymns and prayers.

Q6. What is Vedic culture?

Answer: Vedic culture refers to the traditions, ideas, rituals, prayers and social practices associated with the Vedas.

Q7. What is a yajña?

Answer: A yajña is a ritual in which offerings are made, often into a sacred fire, with prayers for individual or community well-being.

Q8. Who is Agni in the Vedic tradition?

Answer: Agni is the deity associated with fire. Prayers and offerings to Agni were an important part of Vedic rituals.

Q9. What does the statement Ekam sat, viprā bahudhā vadanti mean?

Answer: It means, “Truth is one; the wise call it by many names.” It expresses the idea that different names and forms may point towards one underlying truth.

Q10. What professions are mentioned in the Vedic texts?

Answer: The Vedic texts mention farmers, weavers, potters, builders, carpenters, healers, dancers, barbers and priests, among others.

Q11. What were sabhā and samiti?

Answer: These words referred to collective gatherings or assemblies. They give us some clues about how people discussed matters in Vedic society.

Q12. What does the word rājā mean?

Answer: Rājā means a king or ruler.

Topic 3: The Upanishads and Vedanta

Q1. What are the Upanishads?

Answer: The Upanishads are ancient texts that explore deep questions about life, the self, the universe and ultimate reality. They developed ideas from the Vedic tradition.

Q2. What is karma?

Answer: Karma refers to our actions and their results. It teaches that actions have consequences.

Q3. What is rebirth?

Answer: Rebirth is the idea that life continues through repeated births.

Q4. What is Brahman in Vedanta?

Answer: In Vedanta, Brahman is the ultimate reality or divine essence that underlies everything. It should not be confused with the deity Brahma.

Q5. What is the main idea of Vedanta?

Answer: One important idea of Vedanta is that human life, nature and the universe are connected with one ultimate reality called Brahman.

Q6. Who was Shvetaketu?

Answer: Shvetaketu was the son of the sage Uddalaka Aruni. In a story from the Chhandogya Upanishad, his father taught him about the subtle essence underlying everything.

Q7. What lesson does the story of Shvetaketu and the seed teach?

Answer: The story teaches that something important may not be visible to our eyes. Just as a tiny seed contains the potential for a large tree, an invisible essence may underlie the world around us.

Q8. Who was Nachiketa?

Answer: Nachiketa was a young boy in a story from the Katha Upanishad. He met Yama, the god of death, and asked questions about life and death.

Q9. What do the stories of Shvetaketu and Nachiketa teach us?

Answer: They teach us to ask questions, think deeply, seek knowledge and remain curious about the nature of reality.

Q10. What is Yoga in this chapter's context?

Answer: Yoga is a school of thought and practice that emphasises discipline and the training of the body and mind. It can help people develop concentration and self-control.

Topic 4: Buddhism

Q1. Who was Siddhartha Gautama?

Answer: Siddhartha Gautama was a prince who left his comfortable life to understand the cause of human suffering. After attaining enlightenment, he became known as the Buddha.

Q2. What does the word "Buddha" mean?

Answer: "Buddha" means the enlightened or awakened one.

Q3. Where did Siddhartha Gautama attain enlightenment?

Answer: He attained enlightenment while meditating under a pipal tree at Bodh Gaya in present-day Bihar.

Q4. Why did Siddhartha leave his palace?

Answer: He saw an old man, a sick man, a dead body and an ascetic. These experiences made him think deeply about suffering and the meaning of life.

Q5. What did the Buddha identify as important causes of suffering?

Answer: The chapter highlights ignorance and attachment as important causes of human suffering.

Q6. What is ahimsa?

Answer: Ahimsa means non-violence or non-injury. It includes avoiding harm through actions, words and thoughts.

Q7. What does Buddhism teach about rituals?

Answer: Buddhism teaches that a person does not become truly pure merely by performing an outward ritual. Good conduct, inner discipline and wisdom are important.

Q8. What is an ascetic?

Answer: An ascetic is a person who follows a strict, disciplined way of life to seek spiritual understanding or a higher state of awareness.

Q9. What is attachment?

Answer: Attachment is a strong emotional bond or dependence on a person, object or desire. In Buddhist thought, attachment can contribute to suffering.

Q10. What is the importance of meditation in Buddhism?

Answer: Meditation helps a person train the mind, develop awareness and gain a clearer understanding of thoughts and desires.

Q11. What message does Buddhism give us for daily life?

Answer: Buddhism encourages kindness, self-control, truthful behaviour, awareness and freedom from harmful desires.

Q12. Name some places where Buddhism is practised today.

Answer: Buddhism is practised in India and many other places, including Nepal, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, Thailand, Myanmar, Cambodia, Japan, China and Mongolia.

Topic 5: Jainism

Q1. Who was Mahavira?

Answer: Mahavira was a great teacher of Jainism. He was born into a royal family near Vaishali, in present-day Bihar, in the early sixth century BCE.

Q2. What does the word “Jain” mean?

Answer: The word comes from jina, meaning “conqueror”. It refers to conquering ignorance and attachment, not conquering territory or enemies.

Q3. What is ahimsa in Jainism?

Answer: Ahimsa means avoiding harm to living beings through actions, speech and thoughts.

Q4. What is anekantavada?

Answer: Anekantavada is the Jain idea that reality has many aspects. It teaches us to consider different viewpoints before reaching a conclusion.

Q5. What is aparigraha?

Answer: Aparigraha means avoiding excessive possessions and attachment to material things.

Q6. What is the importance of self-discipline in Jainism?

Answer: Self-discipline helps people control their desires, avoid harmful actions and move towards spiritual freedom.

Q7. What is the difference between ahimsa and aparigraha?

Answer: Ahimsa means not harming living beings. Aparigraha means limiting possessions and reducing attachment to material things.

Q8. How are Buddhism and Jainism similar?

Answer: Both give great importance to non-violence, self-discipline and overcoming attachment. Both encourage people to reduce suffering and seek spiritual understanding.

Q9. How are Jainism and Buddhism different?

Answer: Jainism places particular emphasis on ahimsa, anekantavada and aparigraha. Buddhism emphasises understanding suffering, overcoming ignorance and attachment, and following a disciplined path to enlightenment.

Q10. What can students learn from Jain teachings?

Answer: Students can learn kindness, respect for living beings, simplicity, self-control and respect for different points of view.

Topic 6: Other Schools of Thought — Charvaka

Q1. What was the Charvaka school of thought?

Answer: Charvaka, also known as Lokayata, was a school of thought that believed the material world is the only thing that exists. It did not accept the idea of life after death.

Q2. Why is Charvaka important in this chapter?

Answer: Charvaka shows that ancient India had a wide variety of ideas. People explored different ways of understanding life, the world and reality.

Q3. Did all Indian schools of thought have the same beliefs?

Answer: No. They had different beliefs and methods. Some focused on spiritual reality, while Charvaka focused on the material world.

Topic 7: Folk and Tribal Traditions

Q1. What are oral traditions?

Answer: Oral traditions are stories, songs, beliefs and practices passed from one generation to another through speaking, singing and everyday activities rather than mainly through written texts.

Q2. What are folk traditions?

Answer: Folk traditions are customs, stories, songs, dances and practices passed on among ordinary people within a community.

Q3. What are tribal traditions?

Answer: Tribal traditions are the cultural practices, beliefs, languages, art forms and customs of tribal communities.

Q4. What is a tribe?

Answer: A tribe is a community of families or clans that share a sense of common descent, culture and language and often live closely together. Tribal communities are diverse, so one definition cannot describe every community completely.

Q5. What terms does the Constitution of India use for tribal communities?

Answer: The Constitution uses the terms “Scheduled Tribes” and “tribal communities” in relevant contexts. The Hindi term janjati is also commonly used.

Q6. How many tribes did India have according to the 2011 figures cited in the chapter?

Answer: The chapter cites 705 tribes and a population of about 104 million people in 2011.

Q7. Why should we not call tribal communities “primitive” or “inferior”?

Answer: Such labels are unfair and biased. Tribal communities have rich and complex cultures, knowledge systems, art forms and traditions that deserve respect.

Q8. How do tribal communities express their beliefs through nature?

Answer: Many tribal communities regard mountains, rivers, trees, plants and animals as sacred. Their beliefs and rituals often reflect a close relationship with the natural world.

Q9. What is special about the Toda community's beliefs?

Answer: The Toda community of the Nilgiri Hills in Tamil Nadu regards many mountain peaks as sacred places associated with deities. The textbook notes that the Todas avoid pointing at these sacred peaks with a finger.

Q10. What are Donyi-Polo and Singbonga?

Answer: Donyi-Polo is a form of divine belief associated with the Sun and Moon among several communities in Arunachal Pradesh. Singbonga is a supreme deity worshipped by Munda and Santhal communities, among others.

Q11. What does the tradition of Jagannath at Puri show?

Answer: The chapter describes the tradition that Jagannath was originally a tribal deity. This example shows how tribal and other Indian traditions have influenced one another.

Q12. How have folk, tribal and Hindu traditions influenced one another?

Answer: They have exchanged deities, stories, legends, rituals and ideas over many centuries. This exchange has enriched the traditions involved.

Q13. What is the contribution of tribal art to Indian culture?

Answer: Tribal art preserves community stories, beliefs, knowledge of nature and traditional ways of life. It adds variety and richness to Indian painting, music, dance, craft and other cultural forms.

Q14. Why is it wrong to say that all tribal communities have the same beliefs?

Answer: Tribal communities differ in language, customs, deities, art and social practices. Each community has its own traditions and should be understood on its own terms.

Part 4: Important comparison questions

Q1. Compare Buddhism and Jainism.

Buddhism	Jainism
Its great teacher was Siddhartha Gautama, the Buddha.	Its great teacher in this chapter is Mahavira.
It emphasises understanding and ending	It strongly emphasises non-violence, self-

suffering.	discipline and freedom from attachment.
It teaches that ignorance and attachment are important causes of suffering.	It gives importance to ahimsa, anekantavada and aparigraha.
Meditation and ethical conduct are important.	Self-control and careful avoidance of harm are important.

Q2. Differentiate between the Vedas and the Upanishads.

Vedas	Upanishads
They are among the oldest Indian texts.	They are ancient texts that developed ideas from the Vedic tradition.
They contain hymns, prayers and ritual material.	They explore questions about the self, life, the universe and ultimate reality.
They were preserved through oral recitation.	They include philosophical teachings and discussions.

Q3. Differentiate between folk traditions and tribal traditions.

Answer:

- Folk traditions are cultural practices passed on among common people in a community.
- Tribal traditions are the beliefs, customs, art forms and practices of tribal communities.

Both may be passed on orally and through everyday life. They are important parts of India's cultural heritage.

Q4. What is the difference between a ritual and a belief?

Answer: A belief is an idea that a person or community accepts as true. A ritual is an action or set of actions performed according to a custom or tradition.

Q5. What is the difference between karma and rebirth?

Answer: Karma refers to actions and their results. Rebirth is the idea that life continues through repeated births. Several Indian schools of thought connect these two ideas, though their explanations differ.

Part 5: Important meanings and definitions

Word	Simple meaning
Veda	Knowledge; the name of four ancient Indian texts
Hymn	A poem or song of praise or prayer
Vedic	Related to the Vedas

Yajña	A ritual involving prayers and offerings
Upanishads	Ancient texts exploring life and ultimate reality
Brahman	The ultimate reality in Vedanta
Karma	Actions and their results
Rebirth	Being born again
Vedanta	A school of thought exploring the ultimate reality
Yoga	A discipline involving the body and mind
Ahimsa	Non-violence or non-injury
Anekantavada	The idea that reality has many aspects
Aparigraha	Avoiding excessive possessions and attachment
Ascetic	A person following a strict, disciplined life for spiritual aims
Attachment	A strong bond or dependence on a person, object or desire
Enlightenment	A state of deep understanding or spiritual awakening
Oral tradition	Knowledge and customs passed on by speaking, singing and practice
Folk tradition	Customs and practices passed on among ordinary people
Tribal tradition	The beliefs and cultural practices of tribal communities
School of thought	A group of thinkers sharing similar ideas
Mutual enrichment	Different traditions making one another richer through exchange

Part 6: Quick revision — one-line answers

1. How many Vedas are there? Four.
2. Which is the oldest of the four Vedas? The Rig Veda.
3. How were Vedic hymns first preserved? Through oral recitation.
4. What does Veda mean? Knowledge.
5. What is the ultimate reality in Vedanta called? Brahman.
6. Who was Nachiketa? A boy who asked Yama questions about life and death.
7. Who was Shvetaketu? The son of Uddalaka Aruni in a story from the Upanishads.
8. Who was the Buddha? Siddhartha Gautama after attaining enlightenment.
9. Where did the Buddha attain enlightenment? Bodh Gaya.
10. Who was Mahavira? A great teacher of Jainism.
11. What does ahimsa mean? Non-violence or non-injury.
12. What does anekantavada mean? Reality has many aspects.
13. What does aparigraha mean? Avoiding excessive possessions and attachment.
14. What is Charvaka also called? Lokayata.
15. What are oral traditions? Knowledge and customs passed on by speaking, singing and practice.
16. What does the chapter teach about tribal traditions? They are diverse and have enriched Indian culture.
17. What is one shared idea in Buddhism and Jainism? Non-violence.
18. What does Ekam sat, viprā bahudhā vadanti mean? Truth is one; the wise call it by many names.

19. What does mutual enrichment mean? Different traditions influence and enrich one another.
20. What is one major message of the chapter? Indian culture has many roots, and its traditions have interacted over time.

Part 7: Practice MCQ test

MCQ Practice

0/10 answered

1. How many Vedas are there?

Two
Three
Four
Five

2. What does the word Veda mean?

War
Knowledge
River
Temple

3. How were Vedic hymns first preserved?

Through oral recitation
On printed paper
On palm-leaf manuscripts only
On stone walls only

4. Where did Siddhartha Gautama attain enlightenment?

Vaishali
Puri
Bodh Gaya
Hampi

5. Who was known as the Buddha?

Nachiketa
Siddhartha Gautama
Uddalaka Aruni
Mahavira

6. Which term means non-violence or non-injury?

Karma
Rebirth
Ahimsa
Yajña

7. Which Jain idea means that reality has many aspects?

Aparigraha
Anekantavada
Vedanta
Lokayata

8. What is Charvaka also called?

Vedanta
Yoga
Lokayata
Samiti

9. What is an oral tradition?

Only a written law
Knowledge passed through speech and practice
A type of building
A metal tool

10. What does the chapter say about folk and tribal traditions?

They never change
They are all identical
They have enriched Indian culture through interaction
They have no art forms
Check Answers

Exam preparation tip: Give special attention to the four Vedas, the Upanishads, the stories of Nachiketa and Shvetaketu, the teachings of Buddhism and Jainism, and the contribution of folk and tribal traditions. Learn the meanings of ahimsa, anekantavada, aparigraha, karma, rebirth and Brahman carefully.